



Time: 5 minutes

Outcome: Explain why majority-rule competition can favor the median voter's position under specific assumptions.

Difficulty: Intermediate

Median Voter Theorem

THE CORE IDEA

When policy lies on one dimension, preferences are single-peaked, and decisions use majority rule, the median voter's preferred position has a special advantage. Policies or candidates may move toward it because alternatives on either side can be defeated by a majority.

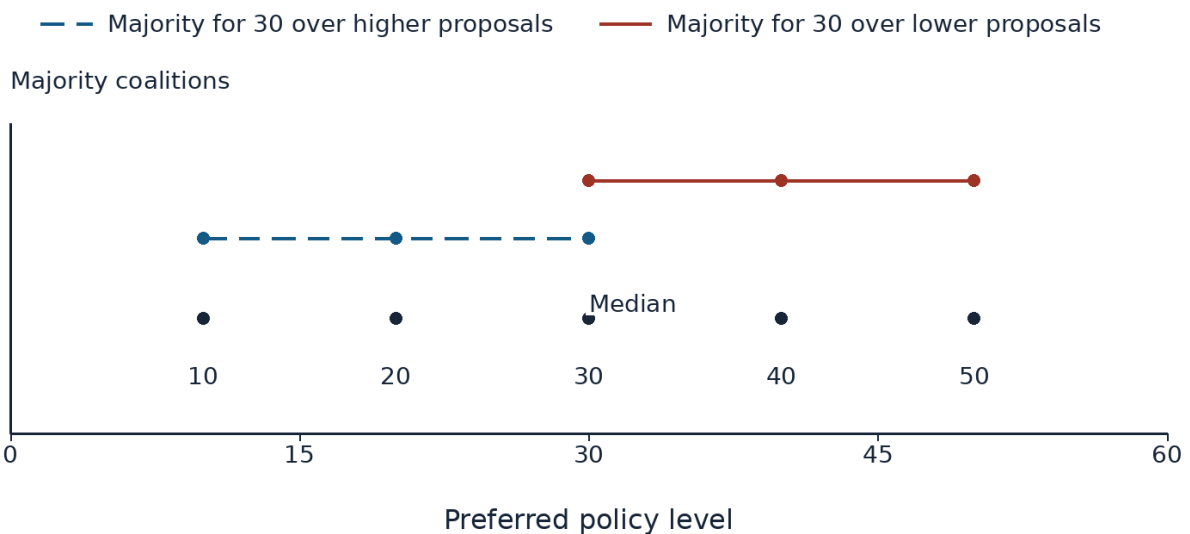
HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- Place voters along one policy dimension and identify the middle preferred position.
- Each voter has a single peak and prefers positions less as they move away from it.
- Pairwise decisions use majority rule.
- Competition can favor the median, but the conclusion depends on these assumptions.

WATCH OUT

The median voter does not always decide elections. Multidimensional policy, non-single-peaked preferences, turnout, institutions, or other departures can break the result.

WORKED EXAMPLE: THE PIVOTAL POLICY POSITION



Five voters prefer policy levels 10, 20, 30, 40, and 50. The ordered middle preference is 30. Against a proposal below 30, the voters at 30, 40, and 50 form a majority for 30; against one above 30, the voters at 10, 20, and 30 form a majority for 30. Under one-dimensional, single-peaked preferences and majority rule, the median position can defeat alternatives on either side.

CHECK YOURSELF

For preferred policies 5, 15, 25, 35, and 45, which position is median, and what preference assumption is required?